

1 Alphabets, Languages, and Grammars

1.1 Terminology

- An **alphabet** (or **vocabulary**) is just a finite, non-empty set. Its elements are called **letters** or **symbols**.
- A **word** (or **string**) is a finite sequence of symbols.
- A word consisting of no symbols is called the **empty word** and denoted λ . (Think ".")
- The set of all words using exactly n symbols from V (repetition allowed) is denoted V^n .
- The set of all words using symbols in alphabet V is denoted V^* . (So $V^* = V^0 \cup V^1 \cup V^2 \dots$)
- A **language** over V is a subset of V^* .

Exercises

1. Let $V = \{0, 1\}$. What is V^0 ? What is V^2 ? What is V^* ?
2. Let $V = \{2\}$. What is V^0 ? What is V^2 ? What is V^* ?
3. Can $\emptyset$ (empty set) be a letter? an alphabet? a word? a language?

1.2 (Phrase-Structure) Grammars

A phase-structure grammar consists of

- an **alphabet**: denoted V here
- a **start symbol** S : S must be (exactly) one of the symbols in the alphabet. We can denote this as $S \in V$.
- **terminal symbols** (T): a set of symbols in the alphabet ($T \subset V$)
 - $N = V - T$ is the set of **nonterminal symbols**
 - so every symbol is either terminal or nonterminal
 - The start symbol is a terminal in some languages and a nonterminal in others
- **production rules** (P): $P \subseteq (V^* - N^*) \times V^*$
 - usually write elements of P as $u \rightarrow v$ rather than (u, v) .
 - $u: V^* - N^*$ says that the lefthand side of the rule (u) must **contain at least one nonterminal**.
 - v : The righthand side can be any combination of terminals and nonterminals (including the empty string).

Examples

Note: in each of these examples, capital letters are used for nonterminals and lower case letters or digits for terminals. That makes it easy to remember, but it is not a requirement of the definition of a grammar.

Grammar 1 (G_1): alphabet: $\{a, b, A, B, S\}$, terminals: $\{a, b\}$, start symbol: S , production rules:

- $S \rightarrow ABa$
- $A \rightarrow BB$
- $B \rightarrow ab$
- $AB \rightarrow b$

Grammar 2 (G_2): alphabet: $\{S, A, a, b\}$, terminals: $\{a, b\}$, start symbol: S , production rules:

- $S \rightarrow aA$
- $S \rightarrow b$
- $A \rightarrow aa$

Grammar 3 (G_3): alphabet: $\{S, 0, 1\}$, terminals: $\{0, 1\}$, start symbol: S , production rules:

- $S \rightarrow 11S$
- $S \rightarrow 0$